

List of GUI applications	
Software Category	Available applications
Development	Kdevelop, Translation, Web Development, Cevisia (CVS fronted), KBugBuster (KDE bug management), KUIViewer, Commander Editor, Umbrello (UML modeller), kjscmd (JavaScript console), etc.
Educational	Various language, mathematics, and science tools.
Games	Various arcade, board, card, tactics and strategy games.
Graphics	GIMP, GQview, KVDI, KFaxView, KGhostView, KSnapshot, KView, KolorPait, Kooka (scanning and OCR program), Krita (image editor), KiuShow, etc.
Internet	Akregator, Firefox, Kget download manager, KMail, KNetAttach (network folder wizard), KNode news reader, Kandy (mobile phone tool), Pidgin, SeaMonkey, Thunderbird, Xchat, etc.
Multimedia	Amarok, Audacious, JuK, K3b, KAudioCreator, KRec (recording utility), KsCD (CD player), Xine, etc.
Office	KOffice, KAlarm (alarm scheduler), KNotes, KOrganizer, KPlato (Palm Pilot tool), Kexi (database creator), etc.

Table 1

However, don't automatically take that conclusion as a bad sign. In fact, I meant it as a compliment. I found the desktop to be more stable than anything I've used in the last few years. Another thing to note is how snappy the desktop appears—it felt so much faster than the alternate distros, that I wonder why the others can't follow suit? Why do they have to be so slow?

I'd like to talk about one area, in particular—package management. Slackware doesn't come with a graphical package manager, so you would have to depend on KDE's Kpackage. This can be used to add, remove and update the packages. Take a look at Figure 2. As for a command line alternative, Slackware does have its own tools here: *installpkg* for installing, *removepkg* to remove packages, and *upgradepkg* to upgrade installed packages. In fact, there are two other commands that you might find useful: *explodepkg* to extract files without installing them, and *makepkg* to create a Slackware package from source files. A handy resource to check whether a Slackware package is already available for a task you need to perform is packages.slackware.it.

Although the distro provides you with a lot of utilities, I guess

people would rather prefer working on the programs they are familiar with. Similarly, I did not find certain software that I frequently use—VLC, Flash, and system monitor (GKrellm) were missing. So, a quick Google search gave me the link to the Slackware 12.2 repository at repository.slackware.eu. From here, you can download the packages that are not currently installed. If it's not here, I recommend checking out the individual software vendor's website first. If a Slack build is not available here, which is likely, Google for a Slackware build.

I downloaded VLC player directly from the VideoLAN website at www.videolan.org/vlc. You can install the VLC package in Slackware by simply using the following command:

```
installpkg vlc-0.9.8a-i486-2alien.tgz
```

Similarly, I downloaded the native Flash tar file provided by Adobe, and used the Adobe default installer to install it after going through the readme files.

After having installed these packages, I tried playing songs in my system. I noticed that I was not able to play music simultaneously on two media players. The reason was

that ALSA was not being configured out of the box, and this sound was default to the age-old OSS drivers. So I configured ALSA by running *alsaconf* from the command line, and that fixed the issue for me.

Another interesting thing is that Slackware comes with the KOffice suite for word processing, spreadsheet, presentation, or database management requirements. I didn't mind using it for a change—in fact, I am writing this article on KWord. However, if you can't do without OpenOffice.org, you can take a look at the repository hosted at rworkman.net/pkgs. In fact, the site has Slack builds for a lot of other useful utilities also.

In a nutshell, I found Slackware 12.2 a very stable version, very true to its motto. Whether I'll stick with it for long, I can't really tell—remember, I confessed that I'm fickle. But if you are someone who vouches for stability, then I've got to say Slackware is the distro for you. By the way, Debian 5 has also been released. :-)



Resources

- Slackware book: www.slackbook.org/html/index.html
- Third-party packages: rworkman.net/pkgs

Slackware 12.2



Pros:

Stable, less resource hungry compared to others, comes with more or less the latest apps.

Cons:

OpenOffice.org and GNOME missing, newbie unfriendly

Platform: x86 or x86-64

Price: Free (as in beer)

Website: www.slackware.com

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The author loves to hack on open source and is a gamer by heart. Oh, and he's part of the LFY bureau too.